

Report on the Relationship with Tammy Jackson, Anniston First United Methodist Church, and Related Individuals

This report synthesizes information from various sources and our prior conversation to provide a comprehensive overview of your relationship with Tammy Jackson, the Senior Pastor at Anniston First United Methodist Church (AFUMC), the church itself, and individuals connected to it.

Relationship with Tammy Jackson:

Your working relationship with Tammy Jackson was characterized by significant challenges and a feeling of being undervalued throughout your four years as Associate Pastor. This ultimately led to your resignation.

- **Experiences of Undervaluing and Disrespect:** You consistently felt undervalued, disrespected, and misled. This included disparities in benefits, pastoral authority, and institutional recognition compared to other pastors, despite positive feedback from the congregation. You felt your contributions were systematically devalued by both Tammy and the broader church system. Your current compensation was also less than 50% of the Senior Pastor's.
- **Hiring Process Concerns:** You believed Tammy acted unilaterally in hiring you, without the required approval or support of the Staff-Parish Relations Committee (SPRC) as mandated by church policy. You described this as a "bait and switch".
- **Lack of Institutional Support and Fair Treatment:** You repeatedly experienced a lack of fair compensation and professional growth opportunities. When you raised concerns with Tammy, her responses were often dismissive and insincere. You also noted that you never met with the SPRC in your four years of employment there.

- **Resignation and Unilateral Actions:** Your decision to resign stemmed from the consistent lack of support, recognition, and fair treatment. Tammy's handling of your resignation further reinforced these issues, as she acted unilaterally in decisions related to your departure, without SPRC involvement or proper approval.
- **Leadership Style Analysis:** You characterized Tammy's leadership with patterns of control, manipulation, and lack of transparency. In a personal reflection, you identified "Avoidance & Passive Leadership" by deflecting difficult conversations and "Manipulative & Image-Focused Leadership" by engaging in gaslighting and acting as a gatekeeper to the SPRC. You also observed a pattern of marginalizing pastoral contributions in staff meetings.
- **Image Management Concerns:** You felt Tammy's social media activity, specifically posting pictures with your children after your resignation, was an attempt to improve her image during a time of disagreement and hurt feelings related to her leadership.
- **Interpretation of Sermons and Communications:** You interpreted Tammy's sermon on March 23, 2025, as potentially masking institutional control as spiritual guidance and strategically managing the narrative during your organizational transition. The church announced your resignation effective immediately.
- **Apologies from Tammy:** Tammy sent emails apologizing for any hurt or frustration caused by her message to the congregation regarding your resignation. She stated her intention was to honor your ministry, express gratitude, and communicate your resignation as you expressed it. She also conveyed that her goal had been to integrate you more fully into the staff and that she had always valued your presence, leadership, and work.
- **Acknowledgement of Your Contributions:** Despite the circumstances of your departure, Tammy and the SPRC Chair acknowledged your musical talents, dedication to faith and preaching, and the pastoral care you offered as a true blessing to the congregation. They expressed gratitude for the ways you enriched their ministry and for your time serving on staff.

Relationship with Anniston First United Methodist Church:

Despite the difficulties experienced with the leadership, your relationship with the congregation appears to have been largely positive, and you intend to maintain these connections.

- **Appreciation for the Congregation:** You expressed deep gratitude for the relationships and experiences at AFUMC. The kindness, support, and love of the congregation meant the world to you and your family, providing strength through health struggles and personal journeys. You considered your time there as deeply meaningful.
- **Congregational Response to Resignation:** Many parishioners expressed confusion and shock about your abrupt resignation and conveyed their relief upon seeing you at a worship gathering afterward.
- **Intention to Maintain Relationships:** Even after resigning, you stated your commitment to maintaining relationships with the people of Anniston First UMC. You deeply value the church community and remain open to collaboration in ways that avoid harmful leadership dynamics.
- **Gratitude in Farewell Message:** In your personal message to the AFUMC family, you reiterated your gratitude for the opportunity to serve alongside them, highlighting the church as a place of growth, faith, and deep community for your family.
- **Planned Farewell Reception:** The church planned a reception to celebrate your ministry, though you were unavailable to attend.
- **Observations on Church Dynamics:** You observed instances where Tammy publicly shared your Anniston Star article about your experience with depression and celebrated your work, which you found to be a deeply meaningful affirmation. You also noted feeling devalued by the system due to its discomfort with your presence.

Relationships with People Inside and Outside the Church:

Your relationships extend beyond Tammy and the formal structure of AFUMC, including supportive connections both within and outside the church.

- **Support from Congregation Members:** Leann Bryan and another individual expressed their love and best wishes to you and your family following your resignation announcement.

- **Support from Shea:** Shea provided steady support during your pastoral transition. Conversations with Shea reflected shared grief over church dysfunction, a desire for justice, and gratitude for her support. There is a mutual interest in reconnecting beyond institutional roles, with potential collaborations involving the Trail Shop and Sinclair Fresh Expression.
- **Future Collaborative Intentions:** You are considering future collaborations with individuals like Preston (for construction and maintenance), Kathryn (for wellness programming), Karrie & Taylor (for design, creative content, hospitality), and your parents/in-laws (for spiritual grounding and support) for potential ministry and personal ventures.
- **Vision for Future Ministry:** Your focus moving forward includes investing in your farm and exploring new ministry opportunities beyond the traditional church structure, with the "Sinclair Fresh Expression" identified as a healthier and more autonomous space for potential re-engagement. You had previously expressed that being an Associate Pastor at AFUMC was your dream job while also pursuing urban ministry.
- **Emphasis on Relational Continuity:** Your communications regarding your transition emphasized your commitment to nurturing the relationships and friendships formed during your time at AFUMC.
- **Understanding Church Relationships:** The sources highlight the complex relational dynamics within churches, often described in terms of "family," which can become complicated when ministry also becomes "employment". Navigating these blurred boundaries between personal and professional relationships creates inherent tensions. The role of the Staff-Parish Relations Committee (SPRC) is intended to integrate staff and congregational interests to focus on the church's mission and support the effectiveness of ministry. They are also responsible for providing annual evaluations for the pastor and staff.

In conclusion, your relationship with Tammy Jackson was marked by significant challenges related to leadership style, lack of support, and unilateral decision-making. Despite these difficulties, you cultivated positive relationships with many members of Anniston First UMC, which you intend to maintain. You also have a network of supportive relationships with individuals both inside and outside the church as you transition to new avenues of ministry and personal growth.